them, there is no such West anymore.

What we need instead is a complete reinvention of the political mainstream. We are in dire need of moderate politicians with firm values and clear vision, left and right, conservative, liberal and social democratic, East and West. Of those that Rachman sees as warriors in the ‘struggle against the strongmen’, Merkel and Macron, one is gone and the other, although re-elected, faces a difficult political situation at home.[256] Others praised as leaders of the liberal West of today have a relatively easy job to dismiss verbally often clumsy conservative authoritarian leaders, but they will need more than just a trendy public appeal and cool images, which tend to bend towards the post-modern and are obviously not inclusive enough. What is needed, is a return to the fundamentals of the West, though not in a fundamentalist way. This is very much a must for conservative governments in Eastern Europe too. It is certainly not tenable to ‘put a reasonable face on rightwing populism’ to get elected, as Steve Bannon is believed to have advised Giorgia Meloni.[257] Their distinct set of values must be rooted in compassion and inclusion, a face of free and open mind. By the same token, rising rightwing populism cannot be an excuse for a witchhunt. A new social contract must patiently and undoubtedly painstakingly be built in a very inclusive way for our liberal democracies to survive.

For the present mood might change and society get tired of uncertain subjectivism and of the loneliness of radical individualism, which could otherwise also start harming the social cohesion essential for a welfare state. But ideological fundamentalism, lack of compassion towards minority groups of all kinds, and new nationalisms will also not address the negative aspects of this globalised world.

As far as the specifics of Eastern Europe are concerned, I have been trying to show how its different history has affected the development of populisms in the region – both before and after World War II and the imposition of the Communist system. The region is unique to the extent that in the twentieth century it experienced all three European totalitarian systems, of which Communism is its latest experience – to many of the people of the region also the dominant one. Combined with the historically late arrival of the Enlightenment and, above all, with relative isolation from social and philosophical developments in post-war Western Europe, this resulted in a specific legacy. The latter has allowed for the preservation of a socially